Singh's visit had much to do with opening a dialogue with the Taliban. In his opinion, the visit can be explained only in the immediate context of the hijacking, and not in the larger strategic context of India's approach towards the Taliban.[157] From the political side, Advani, a staunch partisan, was much opposed to any 'appeasement' of 'terrorists' or those who 'abet terrorists'.[158] Farooq Abdullah, then chief minister of Jammu and Kashmir, was also averse to the idea of releasing the prisoners, and did it only on Dulat's persistent requests.[159] What was clear, according to these partisans, was that India should actively try preventing, if it can, a similar kind of fundamentalist Sunni regime emerging in Kabul.[160]

Singh never said it in so many words that he wanted a 'strategic dialogue' with the Taliban. However, the contours of India's international diplomacy had changed drastically after Pokharan II. The NDA government was actively courting Washington to ease the pressure of sanctions imposed by the US after India's nuclear tests in May 1998. According to some Indian observers, senior individuals in the NDA government knew in the late 1990s and early 2000s (around the IC 814 incident) that non-engagement with the Taliban was not an option anymore.[161] However, this was not a systemic change and many senior bureaucrats were firmly opposed to the idea of engaging with the Taliban (as the above interviews summarily reflect). Such change thinking among India's political leadership apparently stemmed from the realisation that relations with the United Front were unlikely to be sustainable on a long term basis.

India had also tried reaching out to the Taliban through Indian Muslim clerics from the Deoband seminaries in Uttar Pradesh (UP) during the hijack.[162] Being from the same school of the Sunni sect, the Taliban viewed the Deobandis with respect. In fact, the Jamiat-e-Ulema-e-Pakistan, headed by Maulana Fazlur Rahman, the Taliban's ideologue and leader of the opposition in Pakistan (between 2002 and 2007), organised the 134th anniversary of the Deoband seminary in Peshawar just months before the 9/11 attacks which over half a million Pashtuns from Pakistan's frontier region as well as from Afghanistan attended.[163] However, soon after, India's Deobandi clerics termed the Taliban's techniques 'un-Islamic' and disassociated Deobandi Islam from the Taliban's practices. The partisans firmly influenced policy output despite doubts over